

and held serve easily, as she raced to a 5-2 lead. The momentum abruptly switched as Gauff, the game's best defender, used her speed to surge ahead 6-5 after staving off a set point when serving at 4-5. But the American couldn't close the deal, and three forehand errors set the stage for a tiebreaker that would prove critical.

Blasting a backhand winner for a quick mini-break and a 1-0 lead, Sabalenka extended that to 4-0. Controlling her power as well as her emotions, Sabalenka played a superb tiebreaker to prevail 7-2.

Highly animated but much less agitated this season, the new Aryna relentlessly attacked Gauff's second serve. At 4-all in the second set, Gauff saved a break point with a backhand winner only to get broken two points later when her backhand sailed long.

Sabalenka reached match point at 5-4, 40-30, but Gauff boldly struck a forehand down-the-line winner to escape — temporarily. Aryna took the next two points with an ace and Coco's backhand serve return error for a 7-6 (2), 6-4 triumph.

After exacting sweet revenge, Sabalenka smiled and blew kisses to the Rod Laver Arena crowd.

She became the first to reach consecutive finals at Melbourne Park since Serena Williams in 2015-17.

Pointing to her winning 14 of 17 points on Gauff's second serve, Davenport called it "an A-plus performance. All-time great Martina Navratilova said, "She managed her emotions really well."

Gauff, who failed in her last bid to win a major as a teenager, looked at the bright side. "A lot of positives to take. I didn't feel like I played bad. I just felt there were certain points that I just didn't win. So, it's tough with the result, but I'm trying to look at the positives."

The Floridian had plenty of positives to be proud of. Not only did she become the youngest woman to make the AO quarterfinals since Agnieszka Radwanska in 2008 without dropping a set, but she became the first teenager to make back-to-back semifinals at a major

Steely run: Despite not facing a top-50 opponent en route to the final, the 21-year-old Zheng Quiwen dropped three sets, the toughest battle coming against 94th-ranked Wang Yafan. AFP



since 2007 and the first teenager to win 10 straight major matches since Serena.

Winning Ugly — the title of her coach Brad Gilbert's best-selling book — Gauff survived a rollercoaster 7-6(6), 6-7(3), 6-2 battle against unseeded, world No. 37 Marta Kostyuk, the versatile and volatile Ukrainian. After the 3-hour, 8-minute marathon that set a record for her longest Grand Slam match, Coco said, "Didn't play my best tennis, but really proud that I was able to get through. Problem-solving is tennis. Today was frustrating because I knew how I needed to play, I just couldn't execute. Eventually I was able to find it, which is what I'm proud of. Mentally, I'm one of the strongest out there, and I try my best to reset after each point."

In the top half of the draw, major upsets decimated the top seeds. No.

1 Iga Swiatek, who has trouble against power players, rallied from a 4-1 third-set deficit to edge 2021 AO runner-up Danielle Collins 6-3, 4-6, 6-4, but Linda Noskova, a 19-year-old Czech, ousted the speedy Pole 3-6, 6-3, 6-4.

In a lesser surprise, (except for the score), the precocious 16-year-old Russian, Mirra Andreeva, used her superior strokes to trounce No. 6 and three-time major finalist, Jabeur, 6-0, 6-2. "Andreeva is on her way to becoming a superstar," predicted Davenport.

Maria Timofeeva, a 20-year-old qualifier from Russia known as a great fighter, proved it by stunning 2018 Aussie titlist Caroline Wozniacki 1-6, 6-4, 6-1 and 10th-seeded